

Polaroid

The SOCIAL Social Media

Marketing Plan — Technopreneurship Assignment 1

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1. Executive Summary

Polaroid is a mindfulness-first, alternative social media platform built on digital minimalism. It explicitly rejects the manipulative mechanics of mainstream platforms — infinite scroll, algorithmic feeds, autoplay videos, and surveillance-driven advertising — replacing them with intentional, user-controlled features: a daily post limit, analogue-style visual filters, interest-based curation without AI, and full profile customisation through CSS.

The primary target audience is digitally fatigued young adults (ages 17–30) who are increasingly conscious of how current social media affects their attention spans, mental health, self-esteem, and identity.

This marketing plan outlines a hybrid strategy blending non-traditional, community-first approaches with select traditional tactics introduced in a later growth phase. The plan spans three areas:

- **Situational analysis** — market, competition, audience, and internal factors.
- **Marketing strategy** — objectives, positioning, and the marketing mix.
- **Implementation and evaluation** — action plan, budget, metrics, and funding.

2. Situation Analysis

2.1. Market Environment

The social media landscape in 2026 is dominated by a few large platforms whose business models maximise “time on platform” for advertising revenue. The average user spends roughly five hours per day on their phone, with a significant portion on social media. Attention itself has become the core product — not the user experience or social connection.

A growing counter-movement around digital wellness, focus tools, and minimal computing is emerging. Books, podcasts, and communities discuss the negative effects of endless scrolling and the rise of dumbphones, app-blockers, and slow-living lifestyles. This reveals a clear market gap: users who want meaningful connection without manipulation, and who are willing to experiment with alternative platforms.

2.2. Competitive Landscape

Polaroid's real competition is not other apps; it is ingrained user habit. Even users who know mainstream platforms are harmful stay because of strong network effects and the absence of switching costs. Indirect competitors include wellness and mindfulness apps (journaling, meditation, focus timers) and alternative communities (Discord-based wellness groups, niche forums, letter-writing platforms).

Polaroid's key differentiator is offering a social-media-like experience with built-in friction that discourages overuse and encourages reflection rather than addiction.

2.3. Internal Strengths and Challenges

Strengths:

- Clearly differentiated product architecture (daily posting limits, analogue-style design, no algorithmic feed).
- Features that inherently communicate brand values (minimal interface, no ads, no like-count validation).
- Strong alignment with the growing cultural movement toward intentional technology use.

Challenges:

- No existing network effect; Polaroid must help users build a new social graph from scratch.
- Limited budget in Phase 1, ruling out mass-scale paid advertising.
- Requires behavioural change, not just awareness — users must adopt different habits.

2.4. Target Audience

Primary (ages 17–28): Active on mainstream platforms but dissatisfied with how they feel after using them. Interested in productivity, minimalism, slow living, and digital wellness.

Secondary (ages 25–35): Working professionals seeking improved focus and reduced screen time. Likely already experimenting with digital-detox apps or app-limiting tools.

Geographic focus (Phase 1): Urban, tech-savvy youth in Lahore, Karachi, and Islamabad; and digital-wellness communities in the United States and Canada.

3. Marketing Objectives

The following SMART objectives are defined for Polaroid's first 12 months:

1. **Waitlist goal:** Build a pre-launch waitlist of 10,000 engaged users who answer a reflective sign-up question and open at least 50% of preview emails.
2. **User-activity goal:** Achieve 2,000 monthly active users within 3 months of soft launch, where "active" means logging in at least twice a week and interacting with at least three posts.

3. **Media-coverage goal:** Secure coverage in at least 5 relevant publications or platforms (digital-wellness blogs, mindfulness newsletters, tech-ethics outlets). Quality over quantity.
4. **Brand-identity goal:** Establish a distinct, calm, intentional brand identity — consistent visual language and a non-urgent, non-manipulative tone across all channels.

4. Core Marketing Philosophy

Polaroid's marketing follows three core principles:

1. **No paid social advertising.** Paid ads lead to targeting, behavioural nudging, and manipulative copy. Polaroid avoids paid social ads entirely in Phase 1.
2. **No growth-hacking tactics.** No dark patterns, artificial urgency, or viral-challenge mechanics that exploit dopamine loops.
3. **Slow, intentional growth.** The goal is a dense, engaged community — not a large, shallow user base. Retention and depth of engagement take priority over vanity metrics.

5. Marketing Mix (7Ps)

5.1. Product / Service Strategy

Polaroid's architecture is its marketing message:

- **Daily post limit** — forces reflection and reduces compulsive posting.
- **Analogue-style filters** — evokes a nostalgic, slower visual language.
- **Interest-based curation without AI** — users choose topics and feeds manually.
- **CSS-based profile customisation** — expressive but user-controlled design.

5.2. Price Strategy

Phase 1 uses a freemium / open-beta model:

- Free basic access with core mindfulness features.
- Optional premium tier (Phase 2) for advanced CSS customisation, extra storage, and small-group communities.

Pricing is transparent and low, avoiding “freemium traps.”

5.3. Place (Distribution) Strategy

Phase 1: App-store-based (iOS and Android) plus a web version; invite-only waitlist. Phase 2: Partnerships with digital-wellness apps; university-based on-ramp channels.

5.4. Promotion Strategy

Community-first, non-traditional tactics drive Phase 1. Select traditional tactics are introduced in Phase 2. See Section 6 for detail.

5.5. People, Process, and Physical Evidence

- **People:** Community-oriented support staff, moderators, and ambassadors who embody mindful values.
- **Process:** Simple onboarding, clear guidelines, and transparent moderation policies.
- **Physical evidence:** A clean, minimalist visual identity that signals differentiation from cluttered mainstream apps.

6. Marketing Approaches

6.1. Non-Traditional Strategies (Phase 1)

1. **Seeding within existing communities** — direct outreach to 20–30 aligned creators; genuine participation in Reddit, niche forums, and Discord servers; pre-launch Discord for co-creation.
2. **The waitlist as experience** — a minimal landing page with an optional reflective question; email communication framed as personal letters, not automated blasts.
3. **Physical and analogue marketing** — printed cards in cafés, coworking spaces, and bookshops; collaboration with analogue photography communities; participation in exhibitions and zines focused on slow media.
4. **Transparent build-in-public content** — a development blog documenting design decisions and ethical trade-offs; submissions to tech-ethics and mindfulness newsletters.

6.2. Traditional Strategies (Phase 2 — Growth Phase)

1. **Earned media (PR)** — narrative-driven pitches to journalists highlighting real user stories and the human story of Polaroid; submission to ethical-tech awards.
2. **University outreach** — partnerships with mindfulness clubs, productivity societies, and tech-ethics circles; campus ambassadors in Pakistan, the US, and Canada.
3. **Limited print and local-media advertising** — small-scale ads in university magazines or wellness publications; podcast sponsorships focused on digital-wellness topics.

7. Brand Identity and Tone

7.1. Visual Identity

- Dark backgrounds with warm accent tones (amber, soft orange, muted pastels).

- Analogue-style photography: grainy, slightly imperfect images that evoke film cameras.
- No stock imagery or generic illustrations — all visuals should feel authentic.

7.2. Tone of Voice

- **Calm, direct, and honest** — no hype, exaggerated claims, or urgency-based language.
- **No manipulation** — no “limited-time offers” or “only 100 spots left” gimmicks.
- **Self-aware and transparent** — openly admit limitations and trade-offs.

8. Funding, Costs, and Revenue Model

8.1. Funding Goals

Polaroid’s funding strategy is bootstrapped and lean in Phase 1, with external funding explored only once a core community is established and product-market fit is demonstrated.

Funding Stage	Target (USD)	Source
Phase 1 — Bootstrap	\$0 – \$50,000	Personal savings, group contributions
Phase 2 — Seed round	\$50,000 – \$150,000	Angel investors aligned with ethical tech

8.2. Estimated Costs

Cost Item	Phase 1	Phase 2
App development (iOS + Android + web)	\$2,000	\$8,000
Server / hosting infrastructure	\$50/mo	\$300/mo
Domain, email, and basic tooling	\$200	\$500
Community management (time cost)	Volunteer	\$500/mo
PR and outreach (earned media)	\$0	\$1,000
University events and workshops	\$200	\$2,000
Podcast / newsletter sponsorships	\$0	\$1,500
Estimated Phase Total	\$3,000	\$15,000

8.3. Revenue Model — Subscription-Based CSS Customisation

Polaroid’s primary revenue mechanism is a tiered subscription plan centred on CSS-based profile customisation — one of the platform’s most distinctive features.

8.3.1. Why CSS subscriptions?

CSS customisation is deeply aligned with Polaroid’s values: it is user-controlled, expressive, and non-manipulative. Charging for it keeps the core platform free while monetising users who are most invested in personalisation and self-expression. This mirrors successful models from platforms like Neocities and Cohost.

8.3.2. Subscription Tiers

Tier	Price/mo	Price/yr	Included Features
Free	\$0	—	Core platform, default themes, daily post limit, basic feed
Tinkerer	\$3	\$28	Basic CSS editor, 5 saved themes, 100 MB media storage
Artisan	\$7	\$65	Full CSS editor, unlimited themes, custom fonts, 1 GB storage, priority support
Studio	\$15	\$140	Everything in Artisan + small-group community hosting, early access to new features, supporter badge

8.3.3. Revenue Projections

Scenario	MAU	Paid conversion	Monthly Revenue
Conservative (Month 6)	2,000	5%	\$210
Moderate (Month 12)	8,000	8%	\$1,340
Optimistic (Month 18)	25,000	12%	\$6,300

Conversion rates are estimated conservatively based on comparable niche, community-driven platforms. Average revenue per paying user assumed at \$5.25/mo (blended across tiers).

8.3.4. Additional Revenue Considerations

- **Annual plan discount:** Offering yearly billing at 20% off improves cash-flow predictability.
- **Gifting:** Users can gift subscriptions to others — a natural fit for a community-oriented platform.
- **No advertising:** Polaroid commits to zero advertising revenue, preserving user trust.
- **Grants and sponsorships:** Ethical tech grants (e.g., Mozilla Foundation, NLnet) may supplement revenue without compromising values.

9. Marketing Action Plan

Timeline	Activity	Channels / Tools	Owner
Months 1–3	Soft-launch waitlist and landing page	Website, 1–2 social profiles	All (Shammas leads design)
Months 1–3	Build and moderate Discord community	Discord server	Ibtihaj leads
Months 1–3	Outreach to 20–30 aligned creators	Email, DM	Wahab leads
Months 4–6	Launch Phase 1 invite-only beta	iOS, Android, invite codes	All

Months 4–6	Begin build-in-public blog	Dev blog, newsletters	Shammas
Months 4–6	Physical card distribution	Cafés, campus, book-shops	Wahab + Ibtihaj
Months 7–9	Launch CSS subscription tiers	In-app, landing page	All
Months 7–9	PR outreach to tech-ethics press	Email pitches	Wahab
Months 10–12	University partnership events	Campus clubs, work-shops	Ibtihaj + Wahab
Months 10–12	Review metrics and iterate	Analytics dashboard	All

10. Evaluation and Key Metrics

Polaroid will track the following metrics — chosen for depth of engagement over vanity numbers:

- **Waitlist quality:** % of sign-ups who answer the reflective question; email open rate (target $\geq 50\%$).
- **Retention:** % of users active at least twice per week after 30 and 90 days.
- **Engagement depth:** Average replies per post; ratio of meaningful interactions to passive views.
- **Media coverage:** Number and quality of earned-media placements.
- **Revenue:** Monthly recurring revenue (MRR); paid conversion rate by tier; churn rate.
- **Community health:** Moderator-assessed sentiment; user-reported satisfaction surveys.

Metrics will be reviewed monthly by the group and shared transparently with the community in a public “state of Polaroid” update — consistent with the platform’s build-in-public philosophy.